

PSY 240

Cognitive Psychology

How attention, memory, language, and judgment shape everyday thought

FALL 2026 | AUGUST 24 - DECEMBER 18

Instructor	Elena Rivera, PhD
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Class meetings	Tuesday and Thursday, 10:00-11:15 AM
Location	Harbor Hall 118
Office hours	Tue 1:00-2:30 PM; Thu 12:30-2:00 PM; or by appointment
Credits	3 semester credits
Prerequisites	PSY 101 and one college-level statistics course

Course description

This course examines the mental processes that allow people to perceive, attend, remember, communicate, solve problems, and make decisions. Students connect classic experiments with current research and everyday experiences, learn to read empirical evidence carefully, and design a feasible small-scale replication proposal. No prior laboratory programming experience is required.

Learning outcomes

- Explain major theories of perception, attention, memory, language, problem solving, and judgment.
- Interpret the design, results, and limitations of a cognitive psychology experiment.
- Distinguish evidence-based explanations from intuition or anecdote.
- Apply cognitive principles to studying, interface design, communication, and decision-making.
- Develop an ethical, testable replication proposal using APA-style scientific reasoning.

This syllabus is a course roadmap. Dates may shift if campus operations or class learning needs require a change; any revision will be announced in class and in the learning portal.

Materials and learning tools

- Reisberg, D. *Cognition: Exploring the Science of the Mind*, 8th edition. Print or digital access is acceptable.
- PSY 240 Course Reader, available through the learning portal. It contains journal excerpts and instructor-created study guides.
- A laptop or tablet capable of opening PDFs and spreadsheets. Loan devices are available through the library.
- A bound or digital research notebook for observation logs, study sketches, and feedback notes.

How your grade is calculated

Category	Weight / points	What it measures
Applied Cognition Notes (8)	120 pts	Brief evidence-to-life applications; 15 points each.
Laboratory Briefs (4)	220 pts	Methods, results, visualization, and interpretation; 55 points each.
Midterm Examination	180 pts	Conceptual understanding and interpretation of novel examples.
Replication Proposal	300 pts	Question, evidence table, method, peer review, and final proposal.
Preparation and Participation	180 pts	Reading checks, in-class analysis, and constructive peer feedback.

Grade scale

A = 930-1000 | A- = 900-929 | B+ = 870-899 | B = 830-869 | B- = 800-829 | C+ = 770-799 | C = 730-769 | C- = 700-729 | D = 600-699 | F = below 600

Major assignment expectations

Applied Cognition Notes

Eight 500-700 word notes connect one course finding to a concrete situation such as notification design, eyewitness memory, study strategies, or medical decision-making. Each note must state the claim, describe the evidence, and acknowledge one limitation.

Laboratory Briefs

Teams collect anonymous class data during structured demonstrations. Each student submits an individual brief containing a research question, operational definitions, one figure or table, an interpretation, and a limitation. Collaboration ends when analysis begins.

Midterm Examination

The closed-note midterm combines short answers, data interpretation, and scenario-based applications. A one-page instructor-provided concept sheet is allowed; students may annotate it by hand.

Replication Proposal

Students adapt a published cognitive task into a small, ethical study suitable for an undergraduate research setting. Milestones include a research question, annotated evidence table, methods sketch, peer review, and a 6-8 page final APA-style proposal. No data collection occurs.

Assignment calendar

All dates below are firm unless the instructor announces a change. Submission times use Pacific Time. The recurring due-day pattern is shown explicitly so students can plan ahead.

Assignment	Type	Due	Pts
Applied Cognition Note 1: Attention Audit	Short analysis	Tue, Sep 1 11:59 PM	15
Laboratory Brief 1: Visual Search	Lab brief	Thu, Sep 10 11:59 PM	55
Applied Cognition Note 2: Change Blindness	Short analysis	Tue, Sep 15 11:59 PM	15
Applied Cognition Note 3: Working-Memory Load	Short analysis	Tue, Sep 29 11:59 PM	15
Laboratory Brief 2: Serial Position	Lab brief	Thu, Oct 8 11:59 PM	55
Midterm Examination	Exam	Thu, Oct 15 10:00 AM	180
Applied Cognition Note 4: Retrieval Practice	Short analysis	Tue, Oct 20 11:59 PM	15
Proposal Milestone 1: Question + Sources	Project milestone	Thu, Oct 29 11:59 PM	25
Applied Cognition Note 5: Language Framing	Short analysis	Tue, Nov 3 11:59 PM	15
Laboratory Brief 3: Category Learning	Lab brief	Thu, Nov 5 11:59 PM	55
Proposal Milestone 2: Evidence Table	Project milestone	Thu, Nov 12 11:59 PM	50
Applied Cognition Note 6: Heuristics Diary	Short analysis	Tue, Nov 17 11:59 PM	15
Proposal Milestone 3: Methods Sketch	Project milestone	Thu, Nov 19 11:59 PM	50
Peer Review of Replication Proposal	Peer review	Tue, Nov 24 11:59 PM	25
Applied Cognition Note 7: Metacognition	Short analysis	Tue, Dec 1 11:59 PM	15
Laboratory Brief 4: Decision Framing	Lab brief	Thu, Dec 3 11:59 PM	55
Applied Cognition Note 8: Design Recommendation	Short analysis	Tue, Dec 8 11:59 PM	15
Final Replication Proposal	Final project	Thu, Dec 10 11:59 PM	150

Submission checklist

Before submitting: confirm the correct file opened, include your name and course code, cite borrowed ideas, and retain a local copy. A portal timestamp is the official submission time.

Course policies and support

Weekly rhythm and attendance

Most preparation opens Friday. Applied notes are due Tuesdays and laboratory/project work is due Thursdays. Because demonstrations and peer analysis cannot be recreated from slides alone, regular attendance matters. Two absences are automatically excused; after that, students should contact the instructor to discuss a participation plan.

Late work

Applied notes and laboratory briefs have a 48-hour grace window with no explanation required. After the window, work loses 10% per calendar day for up to five days. Proposal milestones may be revised within one week after feedback. The final proposal cannot be accepted after December 14 without an approved incomplete.

Responsible use of generative AI

AI tools may be used to brainstorm search terms, produce study questions, or receive feedback on clarity. They may not generate laboratory interpretations, evidence-table entries, or submitted prose. Any allowed use must be disclosed in a short note naming the tool and describing what was retained or changed. Students remain responsible for accuracy and citation.

Academic integrity

Presenting another person or system's work as your own, inventing data, altering a screenshot, or collaborating beyond the stated boundary violates university policy. When uncertain, ask before submitting. The goal is transparent scientific reasoning, not flawless results.

Accessibility and learning support

Redwood Coast University provides reasonable accommodations through Access and Inclusion Services. Students may share an accommodation letter at any point in the term. Course materials use searchable text, captioned media, and advance posting whenever possible. The Learning Studio offers study planning, writing feedback, and assistive technology consultations.

Communication and wellbeing

Email is normally answered within one business day, Monday through Friday. Include PSY 240 in the subject line. If attention, health, caregiving, food, housing, or technology barriers affect participation, contact the instructor or Student Care Network early so that support can be coordinated.

Weekly course schedule

Complete assigned preparation before the first meeting listed for the week. Due items are repeated here as a planning aid; the assignment calendar remains the authoritative list.

Week	Dates	Focus and preparation	Due this week
1	Aug 25-27	Course orientation; measuring the mind; variables, validity, and ethical inference. Read Ch. 1.	Diagnostic reading check (Thu)
2	Sep 1-3	Perception and selective attention; signal detection; attention in designed environments. Read Chs. 2-3.	Attention Audit (Tue)
3	Sep 8-10	Visual search and divided attention; class demonstration and data visualization.	Visual Search Brief (Thu)
4	Sep 15-17	Working memory models; cognitive load; dual-task evidence. Read Ch. 5.	Change Blindness Note (Tue)
5	Sep 22-24	Encoding, consolidation, and retrieval; desirable difficulties. Read Ch. 6.	Methods practice (Thu)
6	Sep 29-Oct 1	Long-term memory systems; serial-position demonstration. Read Ch. 7.	Working-Memory Note (Tue)
7	Oct 6-8	Memory errors and eyewitness evidence; interpreting confidence. Read Ch. 8.	Serial Position Brief (Thu)
8	Oct 13-15	Integration and midterm assessment; no new reading.	Midterm (Thu)
9	Oct 20-22	Concepts, categories, and expertise; prototypes and exemplars. Read Ch. 9.	Retrieval Practice Note (Tue)
10	Oct 27-29	Language comprehension and framing; proposal question workshop. Read Ch. 10.	Question + Sources (Thu)
11	Nov 3-5	Problem solving, insight, and transfer; category-learning demonstration.	Framing Note (Tue); Lab Brief 3 (Thu)
12	Nov 10-12	Judgment under uncertainty; heuristics, calibration, and base rates. Read Ch. 12.	Evidence Table (Thu)
13	Nov 17-19	Decision architecture and ethics; methods clinic.	Heuristics Note (Tue); Methods Sketch (Thu)
14	Nov 24-26	Peer-review studio; no class Thursday for university holiday.	Peer Review (Tue)
15	Dec 1-3	Metacognition, self-regulated learning, and decision-framing laboratory.	Metacognition Note (Tue); Lab Brief 4 (Thu)
16	Dec 8-10	Synthesis: evidence-based design recommendations; proposal showcase.	Design Note (Tue); Final Proposal (Thu)

End-of-term reminder

Plan backward from the final due date, use office hours before a deadline becomes urgent, and contact the instructor early when circumstances interfere with your work. Asking for clarification is part of successful course participation.